

Paper C: Speaking & Listening

Voice & Vocabulary



THE LONDON SCHOOL
OF ECONOMICS AND
POLITICAL SCIENCE ■

Overview of class



Voice & Vocabulary

- A. Emphasis
- B. Intonation
- C. Pausing
- D. Pace
- E. Idiomatic phrases

A: Emphasis



In English, speakers often show what they think is important by stressing certain words.

Changing the stressed word can change the meaning, attitude, or focus of the message.



How does the meaning change when different words are stressed?



1. **This** study doesn't prove that social media causes anxiety.
2. This study doesn't **prove** that social media causes anxiety.
3. This study **doesn't** prove that social media causes anxiety.
4. This study doesn't prove that **social media** causes anxiety.
5. This study doesn't prove that social media **causes** anxiety.
6. This study doesn't prove that social media causes **anxiety**.

Pair Activity



Student A chooses a sentence and reads it aloud. Student B must identify the intended meaning. Then swap roles.

Example:

Student A: Immigration **can** help address labour shortages.

Student B: Are you suggesting that immigration may help but is not a complete solution?

Student A: Yes.

Sentences:

1. Governments should encourage larger families.
2. Population ageing creates significant economic challenges.
3. Immigration can help address labour shortages.

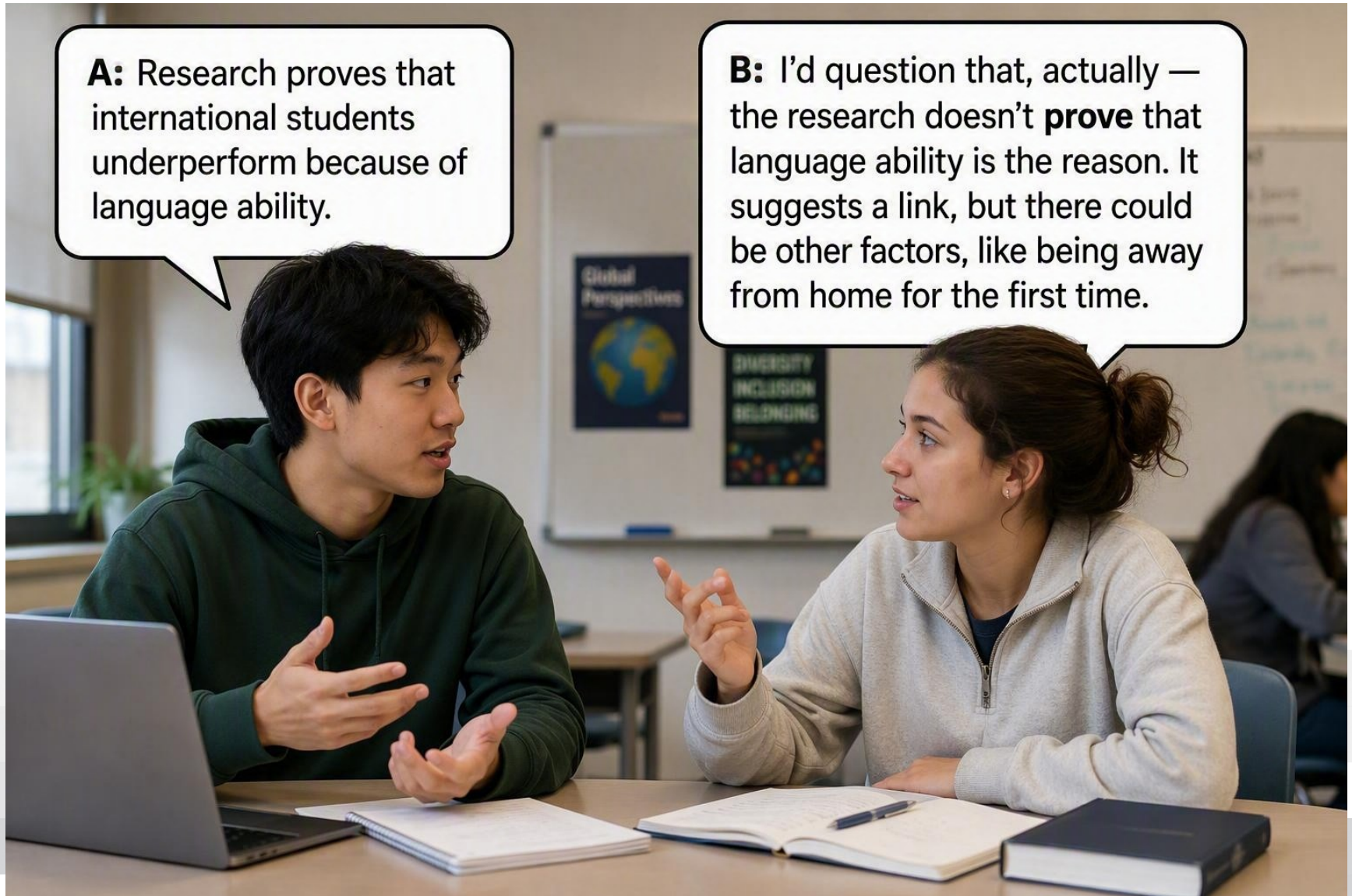
Challenge and response



Work in pairs.

- **Student A:** read out one of the claims on the next slide. Read it confidently, as if you believe it.
- **Student B:** disagree, but only with one part of the claim. That decision tells you which word to stress. Use a phrase to soften your challenge, then give a reason
- **Swap roles** after each claim.

Example:



The claims



1. Research proves that international students underperform because of language ability.
2. The evidence shows that renewable energy can replace fossil fuels entirely.
3. Studies have found that working from home makes employees less productive. It's been proven that early exposure to screens damages children's attention spans.
4. The data clearly shows that raising the minimum wage increases unemployment.

Language to respond:

Softening the challenge	Giving your reason
I'd question that, actually...	It shows the two are related, but...
I'm not sure that's quite right...	That may be true in some cases, but...
I take your point, but...	The evidence only really suggests...
I see what you mean, although...	It depends what we mean by...

B: Intonation



Intonation can change meaning. Read each sentence twice:

- **Version A:** warm, interested intonation
- **Version B:** flat or abrupt intonation

1. That's an interesting point.
2. I see what you mean.
3. That's true.
4. Really?
5. I hadn't thought of that.

Try saying these sentences in 3 different ways

1. Really?

- a) Genuine interest
- b) Doubt
- c) Surprise



2. That's an interesting point

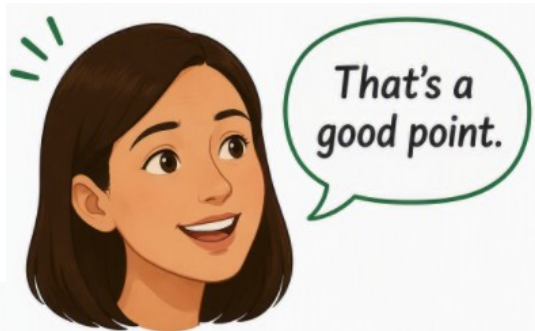
- a) Genuinely engaged
- b) Dismissive, moving on now...
- c) Yes, but...

What attitude am I showing?



Student A say:

- That's a good point



Student B guess the attitude:

- Interested
- Curious
- Sceptical
- Surprised
- Bored
- Supportive
- Unconvinced

Then swap!

C: Pausing



Try to say this sentence without pausing:

Social media has transformed political communication because it allows politicians to reach large audiences directly, but critics argue that it also contributes to misinformation and political polarisation, so governments are increasingly debating whether regulation is necessary.

Now mark places where a speaker could pause and read it again. Compare your version with a partner.

A pause can sound confident rather than hesitant.



Compare:

- I think social media has a lot of advantages but... um... there are also... well... some disadvantages.
- I think social media has a lot of advantages. **[pause]** However, there are also some disadvantages.

Reduce fillers such as *erm, um, you know* and replace them with purposeful silence.



- **Student A** ask a question.
- **Student B** pause for 2–3 seconds, then give an answer

Social media

What are the main advantages of social media?

Is social media harmful to young people?

Gender

How have gender roles changed?

Should universities try to achieve gender equality in all subjects?

Demographics

Why are some countries experiencing population ageing?

What problems can an ageing population create?

D: Pace



You should aim for 120-140 minutes which is around 240-280 words in two minutes.

Style	Words per minute
Very slow	90-110
Clear academic speaking	110-140
Conversational presentation	140-160
Fast	160-180+

Read the text on the next slide naturally and time yourself.

Then calculate your rate: $(\text{Words} \div \text{Seconds} \times 60)$

Discussion:

- a) Below 110 wpm (around 70s or more): Were you too slow?
- b) Above 150 wpm (around 50s or less): Would an examiner struggle to follow?
- c) Around 120-140 wpm (around 55s-65s): Did you sound clear and controlled?

Many countries are experiencing significant demographic change as birth rates decline and populations age. One consequence of this trend is that there are fewer working-age adults available to support growing numbers of older people. As a result, governments may face increased spending on healthcare and pensions. Some researchers argue that immigration can help address labour shortages by bringing younger workers into the economy. However, others believe that immigration alone cannot solve the challenges associated with population ageing. In addition, demographic shifts may affect universities, housing markets, and patterns of consumption. Although these changes create challenges, they also present opportunities. For example, advances in healthcare mean that many older adults remain active and continue contributing to society through work, volunteering, and family support.

2-minute presentations



Prepare a 2-minute presentation responding to one of these questions:

- **Student A:** The world's population is 7.7 billion people. Should we be worried?
- **Student B:** In Japan, more than one in four people are 65 or over. What impact does this have?
- **Student C:** In Nigeria, about 70% of the population are under 30. What impact does this have?

Record yourself on your phone and then listen back. Think about your pauses. Were they hesitant or purposeful?

E: Idiomatic phrases



- Your teacher will give you a set of idiomatic phrases (A, B or C)
- Check you understand the meaning of the phrases and think about how you could use them in a discussion.



Set A



1. To play devil's advocate,...
2. We're only scratching the surface.
3. That gets to the heart of the issue.
4. We may be missing the wood for the trees.
5. It's not as clear-cut as it seems.
6. There's more to it than meets the eye.
7. That opens a whole can of worms.
8. We need to look at the bigger picture.

Sample conversation for Set A



Should governments try to increase birth rates?

A: Many governments are worried about ageing populations and falling birth rates. Do you think they should try to encourage people to have more children?

B: I think they should, but **it's not as clear-cut as it seems**. Birth rates are influenced by housing costs, childcare, careers, and personal choices.

C: I agree. In fact, **there's more to it than meets the eye**. Even generous financial incentives don't always lead to significant increases in birth rates.

A: That's interesting. **To play devil's advocate**, though, if the population keeps shrinking, won't there be fewer workers supporting an increasing number of retirees?

B: That's a valid concern. **That gets to the heart of the issue**. Governments need enough workers to sustain economic growth and fund public services.

C: True, but **we may be missing the wood for the trees**. Instead of focusing only on birth rates, policymakers could improve productivity or encourage immigration.

A: That's a good point. **We need to look at the bigger picture** and think about how different demographic trends interact.

B: Exactly. And if countries start relying heavily on immigration, **that opens a whole can of worms** related to integration, housing, and public attitudes.

C: Absolutely. In fact, **we're only scratching the surface**. Demographic change affects everything from schools and healthcare to economic growth and political priorities.

Set B



1. I think we're splitting hairs at this point.
2. That could be a double-edged sword.
3. It's not a black-and-white issue.
4. We're on the same page about that.
5. That strikes me as a bit of a slippery slope.
6. Let's not lose sight of the main issue.
7. That shifts the goalposts somewhat.
8. I wouldn't rule that out entirely.

Sample conversation for Set B



Should immigration be used to address population ageing?

A: Some economists argue that immigration is the best solution to population ageing.

B: I wouldn't rule that out entirely, but **it's not a black-and-white issue**.

C: Exactly. Immigration can boost the workforce, **but that could be a double-edged sword** if it creates pressure on housing and services.

A: Fair point, **although that strikes me as a bit of a slippery slope**. Not every increase in immigration causes those problems.

B: Perhaps, but **let's not lose sight of the main issue**: how to manage demographic change.

C: **I think we're on the same page about that**. The real question is which policies work best.

A: Shouldn't we also consider productivity and pension reform?

B: Maybe, but **that shifts the goalposts somewhat**. We started by discussing immigration.

C: True, **although I think we're splitting hairs at this point**. All these policies are connected.

Set C



1. Let's not jump to conclusions.
2. We're comparing apples and oranges.
3. That may be treating the symptom rather than the cause.
4. There's a grain of truth in that.
5. The jury is still out on that one.
6. That cuts both ways.
7. It's important to keep an open mind.
8. That puts a different spin on the issue.

Sample conversation for Set C



Should governments offer financial incentives to increase birth rates?

- A: Some governments offer financial support to encourage people to have more children. Do you think it works?
- B: **There's a grain of truth in that.** Financial support can help some families.
- C: Maybe, but **that may be treating the symptom rather than the cause.** High housing costs and work-life balance may be bigger factors.
- A: Good point. Countries with generous benefits sometimes still have low birth rates.
- B: True, but **let's not jump to conclusions.** The long-term effects of these policies can be difficult to measure.
- C: Exactly. In fact, **the jury is still out on that one.** Researchers don't always agree on what works best.
- A: Should we compare countries to see which policies are most successful?
- B: We have to be careful. **We're comparing apples and oranges** if the countries have very different economies and cultures.
- C: That's fair. Also, increasing birth rates could help support an ageing population, but **that cuts both ways.** A larger population also creates greater demand for housing, schools, and infrastructure.
- A: I hadn't thought about it like that.
- B: Yes, **that puts a different spin on the issue.**
- C: Exactly. **It's important to keep an open mind** because demographic challenges rarely have simple solutions.

Discussion



- Work in a groups of 2-3 with students who looked at a different vocabulary set.
- You have 10-15 minutes to discuss the questions on the next slide.
- Try to use all of the expressions in the discussion.

Discussion Questions



1. What, if any, challenges does your country face in terms of population?
2. Is it wrong for couples to have more than two children? Why/Why not?
3. Italy has Europe's lowest birth rates and is said to be heading for a demographic crisis. What can be done about this?
4. China is planning on raising its retirement age as its working-age population shrinks. What are the advantages and disadvantages of doing this?
5. Would you rather live in a country where most of the population are over 65 or where most of the population are under 10?

- How many of the phrases did you manage to use?
- Did you manage to use them naturally?
- Compare your set of phrases with the other sets. Choose 5 phrases to try and use in your next discussion.